LIGHTEN YOUR LOAD · AUSTRALIAN PRODUCE GUIDE

⚠️ Tread Careful

Commonly eaten items that don't belong on the Dirty Dozen - but carry specific concerns worth knowing about. Simple actions reduce risk significantly for most of these.

⚠ **Data note:** "Tread Careful" does not mean avoid - it means be informed. For most items here, simple actions (peeling, buying local, washing well) meaningfully reduce risk. Organic is advisable where the item is eaten daily or frequently by children.

1 

Broccoli & broccolini

Wash well

Lower risk than leafy greens but not negligible. Dense head provides some protection. Wash in running water getting into the florets. Organic worthwhile if eaten daily.

2 

Cucumbers

Peel

Named in AU ATDS monitoring data. Thin edible skin with moderate pesticide use. Sits in the middle of global rankings - not Dirty Dozen but not clean. Peeling removes most surface residues.

3 

Garlic

Buy AU-grown

Most supermarket garlic is imported from China. Friends of the Earth AU: China accounts for ~40% of all AQIS pesticide MRL breaches. Papery skin offers some protection - buy Australian-grown where labelled.

4 

Ginger

Organic

Underground tuber absorbs residual soil pesticides during growth. Almost entirely imported into Australia. Clothianidin detected at high rates in Chinese ginger. Washing is largely ineffective.

5 

Green beans

Wash well

Thin edible pod, high pest pressure. Acephate residues found internationally despite a decade-old ban. AU-specific data is limited but biology is comparable. Frozen green beans are lower risk.

6 

Oranges & citrus

Buy AU-grown

Post-harvest imazalil fungicide (linked to hormone disruption) penetrates the peel into the flesh. Found on ~90% of peeled samples. Imported citrus carries 4× higher levels than AU-grown.

7 

Potatoes

Peel well

90% of samples contain chlorpropham — a post-harvest sprout inhibitor banned in the EU since 2019, still approved in Australia. Concentrated in the skin — peel thoroughly.

8 

Rockmelon

Scrub before cutting

Recent testing found three pesticides on rockmelon, including a systemic neonicotinoid not approved in the EU, and a post-harvest fungicide. The netted rind traps surface residues. Scrub it before cutting so the knife doesn't drag them into the flesh.

9 

Snow peas & sugar snap peas

Wash well

Whole edible pod eaten fresh - no pesticide barrier. Predominantly AU-grown. Only industry-funded residue data available; independent testing is limited.

10 

Tomatoes

Buy local

QLD produce is legally required to be treated with a systemic insecticide dip before interstate transit. Buy locally grown where possible and check origin labelling.

11 

Zucchini

Wash well

Thin edible skin, moderate pesticide use. Similar biology and risk profile to cucumbers. Generally AU-grown with limited independent residue data available.

⚠ TREAD CAREFUL ACTIONS

- → Peel potatoes & cucumbers thoroughly - removes most surface residues effectively
- → Buy AU-grown garlic & citrus - significantly lower chemical load than imported equivalents
- → Buy local tomatoes - avoids the QLD mandatory interstate transit insecticide treatment
- → Organic ginger worthwhile for daily users - soil absorption makes washing largely ineffective
- → Choose frozen green beans over fresh - blanching before freezing degrades residues meaningfully

Sources: FSANZ ATDS · Friends of the Earth AU (2012) · CHOICE · NRS · APVMA · EWG Shopper's Guide (2026) · Guardian AU FOI · Hort Innovation (2025) · Pesticide Action Australia · Full source list →

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